Burners Muster

Ok boys, check your kit, check your weapons, it's today. You get a pint and a chaser, no more. Let's go

Boss, **retainer**, **Muster**, **Muster slots**. Framed after OSE Retainers. Heart 1+ unlocks Muster in [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Someone left at camp or castle is not on the adventure. Week-rate services and garrison wages live on [[Burners Equipment]]; they are not this page until they march with you. A specialist (or anyone else) who ends up on the job — a rescued prisoner, a sage dragged into the barrow — is a **retainer for that stretch**: same sheet, Loyalty, XP, and Muster rules.

Retainers

NPCs hired to share the risks of adventuring with the party. They will not keep working if treated poorly; a disgruntled retainer spreads word and makes hiring harder.

Anyone with coin can hire. Only a **Boss (Heart 1+) Musters** — splitting the twelve into physical kit and **Muster slots**. How many Muster slots you declare is the Burners answer to OSE's Charisma retainer limit.

Recruitment. Taverns, help-wanted notices, dockside crews, debts called in. The Referee plays the applicants. Explain the job and the share; Reaction roll (see [[Burners Referee Guide]]); Heart on the roll if you have it. A fair outfit and a clear half-share ease it; bad reputation hardens it.

Pay. No up-front wage for the adventure. You **equip** them from your purse (arms, kit, food on the road). Survivors of the job take at least a **half-share** of treasure taken — that is their pay. Flat coin alone will not buy a delve.

Sheet. Half-power track (below). Usually starts **level 1**, climbs on XP, never above the hiring Boss (or lead PC). **Sword or Craft only** — never Sorcerie, never Heart, never Muster. By default they **put themselves first**. **Loyalty 7.**

XP. Same shape as OSE for retainers who are **not** Mustering: in the pot's divisor, keep half of a share (that **taxes** party XP). **Muster** is the Boss's answer: seats are **out of the divisor** — the party is not taxed — and Mustering retainers on that job split **half of their Boss's XP** (one seat gets the whole half; several split it). Levels on the Burner XP table when they next sleep somewhere safe. Full procedure: [[Burners Experience]].

Loyal is a **tag** after a real bond (Referee's call). +3 Loyalty; when they hold, they **act loyally** — prioritize their patron, Block for them, stay on their heel. Abuse the bond and the tag can fall — word travels.

Starter (Boss). A Boss at character creation begins with the twelve split **9 physical + 3 Muster**, and one **loyal retainer** Mustering (the other two Muster seats open): level 1, Sword 1 or Craft 1, 2 Traits, HP = **1d3**, Loyalty **10** (7+3), basic kit paid from the Boss's purse, and a **half-share** of the take when they live. Taking Heart 1 later does not grant this retainer — see *Starting kits are for new characters only* in [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Half Power

Retainers are not Burners. **Everything that scales with level or Approach is halved, round down** (see *Manage* for the only round-up):

Piece	Rule
Traits	**2 per Approach level** (half of a Burner's 4 under that Approach)
Signatures	At most **⌊Approach / 2⌋** per Approach — earned in play, never bought
HP	**1d3 per retainer level** (about 2 per level on average; minimum **1**). On level-up: reroll the whole total (keep higher of new total or old+1).
Fuel maximum	**⌊retainer level / 2⌋** + empty slots (up to 4); minimum **1**
Veteran extras	**⌊Sword / 2⌋** extras (Sword 1 → one attack)
Approach rolls	**`2d6 + ⌊Approach / 2⌋`**
Shock and other Approach math	Same half (Shock: **`2d6 + ⌊Sword / 2⌋`**)

Not halved: shares, Muster slots (**1 per retainer**), Loyalty, kit on their person. Armor still soaks. Full Wound and Shock once HP is spent.

Who plays them

- **Mustered:** like a second sheet — the **Boss's player** plays and rolls. No fight Loyalty checks while the Boss is **active**.
- **Not Mustering** (or hired by a non-Boss): **NPCs** run by the Referee; Loyalty checks fire more often (see *Loyalty*).

After-adventure Loyalty (will they stay?) still belongs to the Referee for everyone.

Manage (Boss Action)

Default: half, always round **down**.

Managed: The Boss spends **their Action** that round to **manage** the Muster — the Boss takes no other Action that round. Until the next Roll Initiative, up to **Heart** Mustering retainers (your choice if you Muster more than Heart) use **half round up** for Approach rolls, Shock, Veteran extras, and the level part of their Fuel maximum. HP on the sheet does not rewrite mid-fight. Excess Mustering retainers stay at half down.

- One Action → up to **Heart** Mustering retainers that round.
- Only retainers you are Mustering.
- Managing again next round costs another Action (no Boss Action of your own that round).

Traits

Job names are Traits, tagged to Sword or Craft. A retainer fills their item slots for that work; the Boss outfits upgrades from the purse.

Packbearers carry baggage and keep simple items handy: rope, waterskin, and the like.

Fighting men hold Sword-tagged Traits for preferred arms and kit — spear, arming sword, shield.

Lantern bearers (linkboys, torchbearers) hold *lantern-bearer* or *torchbearer*. Lantern or torches, flint and steel, oil.

Shield bearers hold *shield* / shield-bearer. Chief work: resupplying fighters with fresh boards.

Squires keep weapons ready (*"Squire, my sword!"*). They may help a fighter don armor.

Animals (not Muster)

Muster seats **people**. A mule bought to haul, or a horse you ride, is a **bought asset** — off the twelve, not a Muster slot. Prices: [[Burners Equipment#Animals and mounts]].

A **trained, named** companion (your warhorse, your dog) is a **Signature** on the Trait that covers the work — not a retainer and not a Muster slot. See *Signatures* on [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Muster Slots

Each Mustering retainer costs **one Muster slot**. One person, one slot. Care and treatment modify **Loyalty** — not slot cost.

Muster (Heart 1+)

Before a job — in town or at the safehouse — or on any **8-hour sleep**, the Boss **Musters**:

1. Declare the **physical / Muster** split of the twelve.
2. Place named retainers — **one Muster slot each**.
3. Lock the Muster for the run until the next Muster.

Going alone: **0** Muster slots, all twelve physical. Retainers wait at home — off this page until Mustering.

Muster slots hold **people**, not gear. Kit rides on them; outfit and new gear come from the Boss's purse. They never count as empty slots for Fuel. See [[Burners Adventure Game]].

Muster slots buy packing, Manage, **Boss-player control**, **no fight Loyalty while the Boss is active**, and **Heart on Loyalty checks** — not a different XP track, and not Fuel.

Non-Bosses may still hire retainers. Without Muster, by the book the Referee runs those NPCs. **Table practice (preferred):** the **hiring player's player** still rolls and plays the hireling in a fight — Initiative, Fuel, attacks — so the retainer is not stuck last as a forgotten Ref turn. The Referee keeps **Loyalty** checks (and takes the sheet back if the hirer is down, fled, or absent). Mustering remains the Boss privilege for Muster XP (half the Boss's award, split among seats), no-fight-Loyalty, and Manage.

Loyalty

Retainers use **Loyalty**, not monster Morale. When a check is called, the Referee rolls **2d6**: if the roll is ≤ **Loyalty** (with modifiers), they **hold**; if higher, they **break** — flee, freeze, drop the torch, demand to leave, or quit after the job. Play it by fiction.

Base Loyalty 7. Loyal tag: **+3**.

Mustered. Played by the Boss's player, as a PC would be. **No Loyalty checks in a fight** while the Boss is **active**. If the Boss is down, fled, captured, or otherwise out of the fight, Loyalty checks resume — including extreme peril. After the adventure, check whether they stay on (as OSE). Whenever a Mustering retainer checks Loyalty, **add the Boss's Heart** — unless the Boss is down, fled, or absent (then Heart does not apply).

Not Mustering. Referee NPCs. **Check more often** in the press — ordinary fight scares, first ally felled, side half hurt or dropping, clearly losing, or any shock the Referee judges — plus after the job. No automatic Heart.

Common modifiers (Referee's call, as in OSE):

Situation	Typical mod
Mustering retainer (Boss active)	+ Boss's **Heart** (always)
Well kept (outfitted, fed, fair half-share, decent treatment)	+1
Neglected (shorted share, cold, mistreated, sent unarmed)	−1 or −2
Boss down, fled, or absent	−2 (no Heart)
Overwhelming foe or sudden disaster	−1 or −2
Generous treasure promised or just paid	+1

A **loyal** retainer who holds **acts loyally** — they prioritize their patron over their own skin when the fiction allows. An ordinary retainer who holds still looks to their own hide first.

Without a Boss, the Referee checks against base Loyalty with situational mods only — and uses the **not Mustering** cadence.

Garrison (pointer)

Month-hire soldiers for walls and armies are OSE mercenaries — not adventure companions. Rates and notes: [[Burners Equipment#Hirelings and specialists]]. If individuals march into a delve with the PCs, treat them as retainers for that stretch.

Becoming a Burner

A retainer becomes a full **Burner** only when they become a **PC**. Until then they stay on the half-power track.

On that claim: PC **at their current retainer level**. Rebuild under full PC rules — 4 Traits per Approach level, full HP, full Approach math, one Signature per Approach level, open Approaches.

Professional Adventurers

The Referee may field a rare **professional adventurer**: an NPC built as a PC. Uncommon. Not a retainer upgrade path.

Example Retainers

All examples use half power (round down) unless a Boss **manages** them that round (up to Heart at once). Each Mustering retainer costs **1** Muster slot.

Cob — lantern bearer

- **Level 1, Craft 1.** HP **1d3**. Loyalty **7**.
- **Traits (2):** *lantern-bearer*, *quiet* (Craft).
- **Kit:** hooded lantern, flask of oil, flint and steel, spare torch.
- Half-share when the haul comes home.

Merrin — packbearer

- **Level 1, Craft 1.** HP **1d3**. Loyalty **7**.
- **Traits (2):** *packbearer*, *broad-backed* (Craft).
- **Kit:** rope, waterskins, spare rations, room for the haul.
- Road and barrow; climbs on XP.

Bren — shield bearer

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP **1d3**. Loyalty **7** (+1 well kept / −1 neglected).
- **Traits (2):** *shield-bearer*, *steady* (Sword).
- **Kit:** two heaters, spare buckler, leather.
- Puts self first.

Tam — squire

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP **1d3**. Loyalty **7**.
- **Traits (2):** *squire*, *arming sword* (Sword).
- **Kit:** master's spare blade, oil, strap kit.
- Proud of the harness; looks to his own skin when the line bucks.

Nell — spear (loyal)

- **Level 1, Sword 1.** HP **1d3**. Loyalty **10** (7+3 loyal).
- **Traits (2):** *spear*, *steady under fire* (Sword).
- **Kit:** spear, gambeson (AC 2), kettle helm.
- Starter bond for a green Boss. Outfitted from the Boss's purse; half-share when she lives. When she holds, she prioritizes the Boss.

You don't give your strength away. You make others braver than they have any right to be, and lead them somewhere they'll probably regret.